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Red Pastures

by Burt Burlington

Me and my family love living off the land,

But I never expected the land living off us.

As the three suns were rising, the Algeon-hen screamed its annoying high-pitched cry over the farm all too well, I knew it was time to feed the animals. As I removed my flower embraided blankets carefully; so not to damage the so lovely made by my mother, I looked at the tambour clock on my wooden dresser. 15:32. *The water cock was early today.* As I looked from the window from my bedchamber, I could see a small sliver of light rise slowly over my daddy's ranch. As far as my eyes could reach, Auridents were rummaging between each other, covering the dark red sands.

Sitting on a small stool in my red simply sweet dress in front of my vanity table; which daddy told me was mahogany, I sat braiding my hair into pigtails as I do every morning. The braiding took a lot of time and I also didn't like that I was compelled to do it by Mother, fortunately I always liked how my blond hairs looked with it.

“Veva, can you help me with breakfast,” Mother yelled while standing at the bottom of stairs.

“Coming, Mother!”

Quickly tying my prairie bonnet on my head, sadly, hiding all the work I spent, I rushed down to help mother. She was already busy kneading the bread, in her equally pretty purple flower dress.

“Honey, can you set the table” she said without looking back at me.

“Yes ma'am.”

I picked the red and white squares table cover which is my favorite, and while waving it over the dining room table, I could see daddy exiting the outhouse through the window.

Six forks, six knives, six plates, all placing them symmetrically to each other like mother likes. Then father walks in through the back door.

“Morning, sweetheart,” he says under his grey moustache.

“Morning, daddy!” I ran up to him and gave him a big hug.

After crouching down to hug me he stood up and gave me a rub on my head. While looking down at me and holding his belt buckle- like he o’ so reguraly did – he said:

“Are you gonna help daddy with the animals today? Daddy is in need for some extra pair of hands.”

I was shaken, but excited and nodded enthusiastically. Mother showed her unappreciation by slamming the bread hard on the wooden cutting board.

“What are you'll jibber-jabbering about? Veva is gonna help me clean the farmhouse this afternoon,” she miffed.

“Well, Quint is probably still in town, trying to sell a pair of Auridents and a dozen of Sescentipedes, so I won't expect him home anytime soon.” Father crouched down to me and

looked at me with a friendly smile. It was always so welcoming to see his thick grey moustache curl up. “And I need a strong girl to help me out today.”

“You are not bringing her in with the Groglytes, Kennon.”

“Of course not Karen, she will help with collecting the Algeon-chicken' eggs, feed the Sescentipedes, and help me cut the teeth of the Auridents,” he said with his gravelly voice.

“Okay. But I want her back before supper so she can help me,” she said.

I was happy that I didn't have to help with the Groglytes, they are scary big and are quite stubborn. He nodded and stood back up, “You get your boots, I will be at the chicken pond.”

I enjoyed when daddy and mother had a discussion, mother's honey sweet voice and daddy's rocky voice sounded so funny together; but I didn't like when they started arguing.

I loved how my green boots matched with my red dress. As I walked over dark orange sand towards the chicken pond, I saw Timmy and Barry play in the orange mud. They seemed to used the green hand pump next to them to cover the sand in water.

“Hey! Daddy says you can't waste water from the pump, you should be careful with it.”

I yelled at them from a distance. While wrestling in their already fully muddy covered clothing, they looked at me.

“What do you know?” Barry said

“I know more than you two, daddy even asked me to help him today,” I rebutted.

“Oh finally, someone who can fish out the eggs from the pond, our hero,” Timmy said while standing up from the mud. I stucked my tongue out to them and continued my journey to start my day of labor.

I didn't mind fishing out the Algeon eggs from the pond. They wouldn't hurt me; they were even quite sweet and would caress me with their squishy skin. The feeling of the grabbing the eggs was quite unpleasant because they were like waterfilled balloons which felt

like they could burst any second. After having collected a bucket full, I brought it back to the basement under the farmhouse. There we had this industrial fridge where we stored all the meats, butter and eggs.

When walking to the Sescentipedes cage, I walked past the Groglytes meadow. The fences of the whey were five times bigger than me. Even if I was as old as my oldest brother Quint, I would only come to half the size of the fence. The high fences were needed for the big horse creatures. They were intimidating, but also rich in vibrant colors. The Groglytes had all their organs on the outside of their skin. Their muscles were a strong dark blue and their heart was red, stomach green, intestines yellow etc. If all three of our Groglytes would stack on top of each other, they would be as big as our house. I didn't want to look at them for too long because I was afraid they would get angry, so I averted my gaze and continued on my walk to meet daddy.

Our main host star was right above our heads and the two moons were on parallel sites of the star, which meant that it was 20:00, mid-day.

When I got to the Sescentipedes coop which was enclosed in a big wired cube which made it impossible for the pedes to wander off. Daddy was already picking out the oldest and biggest ones to sell at the market back in town and putting them in cages. They have perfectly round bodies, but no eyes, mouth, nose or ears. They use the uncountable hairy thin legs to feel vibrations and hold their body in the air and safe between its legs. You could hardly see their body because of the millions of legs that surrounds it. I remember when my aunt came to our farm she was terrified of the little buggers. She didn't want to touch, let alone look at any of them. Once we brought one into her room at midnight. She screamed so hard that the Auridents started to bleat in the meadow, it took the entire night for them to stop. It would probably be her biggest nightmare to walk between hundreds of these cute little balls of legs. Their legs were soft and fluffy and they couldn't bite because they didn't have mouths. They

would absorb food by picking it up with one of their legs and sticking it to the underside of their body. I would sprinkle seed on the coop floor, which they would feed on.

“You are really getting the hang of it aren't you, Veva?” daddy said while picking up a pedes and put it in a small cage.

“Yeah, I love being with the animals and help you,” I said while I finished my last bag of feed.

Father moustache curled up; “Well ain't you a darb, we can really use you on the fields more regularly”.

I was exploiting out of excitement; being able to make a real impact on this farm is something I always wanted. *But how could I abandon mother, leaving her all alone to do the house chores?*

I quickly forgot when daddy said “You gonna help daddy with cutting the Auridents teeth?”

“Yessir.”

We had to cross the entire estate to get to the workshop, which was on the other side of the Auridents pen. Their enclosure was the largest of all of the animal enclosures we had, even bigger than the Groglytes meadow. That was because we had thousands of Auridents. Daddy told me it was rare for a farm to have Auridents because they were so pricey, and it was especially rare to have so many of them. But because we were so lucky to be appointed by “Space Suite High Engine Ships” company, and farm the gold they in turn use for their vessels, we didn't have to buy them. They “subsimized” them for us or something. Daddy told us we had 5730+ Auridents. Luckily, we didn't have to cut all of them or else we would be her in four hundred solar lapses.

Auridents were my favorite animal on our farm because they made the cutest noise and their hair was dark blue and soft. What was of course special about them is that their teeth grew completely out of gold all year long. My favorite Aurident was Trisberry, named

after the berries that grow on the other side of the planet. Because she had less – what my daddy told me - “tellurium” in her blood when she was just a pupa, she wouldn't develop the same yellow colored triangle plates over her back like the rest. She would instead have pink colored triangular plates which looked so adorable. That is why I named her after the berries which have the same color. Daddy opened the gate between the workshop and the enclosure. Betwixt the two is a fenced off way that would lead the Auridents from their kin, to inside the workshop.

This was the first time I was allowed inside the workshop, “because the workshop is not for little girls,” like Barry always said, even though he himself was not yet permitted. Wooden crates, one hammered close and two yet to be filled were standing in the corner of the room. Three large lights -one parallel to the ground and the other two diagonal facing inside, hanging above the metal contraption in the middle of the room. On the wall were different kinds of syringes, spanning from annoyingly stinging small to absurdly scary big. The same was for the silvery titanium clippers. I had difficulty understanding what I was seeing. Dad opened the doorway that was connected to the pen. Quickly, one of the Auridents made its way into the workshop by a laser-fence, forcing the creature to remain on course to the workshop from the enclosure. As the six-footed arch-legged saunters in, daddy picked it up without reservation. The thing made a high-sounding bleat because of the roughness. I was a bit shocked, but before I was able to process it, daddy already asked me; “can you strap the belt over his back,” when he placed its belly on the metal rig. And so I did. He picked a weird looking silver thing, which seemed to have no real purpose at all, covered in limescale. But the dirty thing had a purpose. Daddy shoved the thing in the Auridents mouth, and in less than three pumps, the mouth opener was in full extension. A quick little squirming squeak came from the animal's throat. “You hold this so that the mouth doesn't close back shut,” daddy instructed; “you don't want daddy to lose a finger,” he said with smile. While he was looking at his tool wall, I looked into the animal's expression. It seemed to mirror my own.

Both of us had fright and confusion written in our eyes. Daddy found his medium sized cutter. It didn't take long for him to place the sharp sounding weapon in the living thing's mouth.

“Okay, hold him steady.”

SNIP.

The pliers went through the golden tooth as if it was hard butter. The animal screamed. As if it was almost human. The tooth tinged when it dropped to the ground. It tried to thrash around, but it was locked in place.

“Hold it Veva, three more to go.”

As daddy was placing the pliers around the second tooth; I pressed my head into the neck fur of the Auridents, desperately trying to not hear the scream. My attempts were futile, because I could hear the screams travel through the poor animal's throat.

SNIP.

TING.

SCREAM.

That was all I could hear and wanted to remember. Daddy unstrapped the unteethed animal and sent it on its way outside the workshop.

Before I knew it, I had already was walking towards the door, grabbing the doorknob, when daddy grabbed me by my shoulders.

“What's wrong sweetheart?”

I didn't respond, I didn't know what to say, I couldn't speak.

He turned me around.

“Oh dear, you look so pale.”

A cold shock traveled down my spine, I shivered. That was the moment when I remember seeing daddy again. He crouched down to eye level.

“Did you find the noises scary?”

“No... no.” I said, seemingly have gotten power over my tongue again.

“Well, what is it?”

I looked him in the eyes; “you heard that animal, so much.”

“Oh sweetie,” he smiled under his moustache, “that didn't hurt him.”

“Listen here sweetheart, they don't have so much feeling you see, and if they do, it doesn't hurt so much. It is not even as bad as you stub you're toe against the table. It was just a little scared, which is normal. It is a bit scary because it doesn't know what is happening. But now he's back with his family and he probably doesn't even remember it anymore.”

I looked at him, then at the ground. I nodded. But then I looked back up at him again.

“But do we have to do this?”

“Well,” he said; “people need that material of which their teeth are made very badly.”

“And it is very expensive to take care of all of them. So see it as a way for the animals to pay us back by feeding them, keeping them safe, and keeping them comfortable.”

I swallowed, as if swallowing a big pill. I nodded without looking at him.

He placed his hand on my shoulder; “Okay, great. Now let us continue because we have to do a couple more.”

Individual life after individual life stepped in through the gate. The routine was exactly the same.

Strap.

Snap.

Ting.

I don't know if the feelings were becoming easier to handle, or I was losing my sense of self.

After every switch up he would pick up the teeth – some still seemingly with blood on them- and throw them in the wooden case. The second crate seemed to be close to being full. He looked in it and said; “seems like we only have space for one more, so this is going to be

the last one". As happy as I was that it was almost over, faded quickly when I saw who it was.

"Trisberry!" I screamed in my head.

Trisberry, limps into the workshop with her six feet, the plates on her back moving left and right. Father walks up to her and extends his arms. But I rush in front of him and embrace Tris with my arms around her neck. "No, not Trisberry!".

"Sweetie, that is not how it works..."

"No please, not. Not her."

"It's better for Tris to get cut as well because it is -."

As father's voice zoned away, I could hear the heartbeat of Trissy with my ear pressed againsts her lower neck. The heartbeat sounded irregular. Way different when I would lay against her when we would look at the moons coming up. I also noticed her skin feeling hot, as if almost boiling. I stood up and looked at Trisberry.

"I think Trissy is sick," interrupting father.

Father frowned and took a look closer. He felt the back of the neck. Immediately he felt the sweltering heat from her.

"Hmmm, this ain't good, I have never seen this."

"What should we do?" I looked up at him while holding frowning Trissy's head.

"Just bring her back and get the next one."

"We can't do that, we need to take care of Trissy!"

"Sweetie, we don't have time, it is almost supper and we need to head back." dad said in a rare annoyed tone.

"I am not going to let Trissy suffer like this."

Dad looked up at the ceiling, sighed.

"Alright, whatever you want to do."

Father walked to the case with teeth and looked inside. "They won't miss a few," he mumbled in himself.

"Where can we put Trissy?" I asked.

Daddy put the top on the crate, "I don't know. Maybe it can cool off in the shadow." He clearly didn't care. The shadows were even hotter than inside the workshop. I needed something cooler.

"Can she stay in the refrigerator in the basement?"

"Absolutely not."

"Even for a short while?"

"She only needs a short while to eat all the eggs and meat."

"But daddy, don't you care about Trissy?"

Father looked down at me hugging the sickly looking Trissy. He curled his mouth in doubt.

He looked back at the crate, back at us. He walked to the other side of the workshop, at the syringes and the pliers. He slid open a drawer and put his hands in it.

"If you make her wear this, she can stay for an evening," and threw a muzzle to me. I looked at the intimidating thing, unsure to feel glad.

I just placed Trissy in the middle of the fridge. She laid with her multiple legs wrapped under herself. The white neon lights were incandescently bright. Luckily, from knowing when my little brothers locked me in the refrigerator to tease me, I knew the lights would turn off when the door closed. As much as I was happy that I could help Tris in some way, it still was bittersweet to see her with a muzzle.

"Veva, come up here, supper is ready!"

"Coming!"

I slowly closed the refrigerator door, peeking my head in as long as I could to make the feverous Trissy feel safe.

“Now Veva!”

“Coming!”

Mother was noticeably angry for not helping her with supper today.

When I entered the dining room, everyone had already taken their seat. I always sat beside Timmy, while Barry sat diagonally across from Timmy, because they weren't allowed to sit beside each other. Daddy and mother sat at each table ends opposed to each other.

My plate was already made, two cooked Sescentipedes bodies which were coarse round balls, with all the red color cooked out. As a side dish, a cooked algeon egg lay beside them.

“Don't flip your wigs about supper today, I didn't have time to prepare anything else” mother said, obviously bothered. The only response for a while were cutlery hitting the plates.

“Oh, I like it Karen” dad stepped in.

He poked Barry who was sitting beside him; “and you?”

Barry looked up; “Oh yeah, really very delicious.”

Mother looked at Barry, then to me. I haven't taken a bite. I was just rolling the cadaver bodies from one side of the plate to the other.

“And you Veva, you like it.”

I didn't hear her, I was inspecting the spots where the legs of the animal were.

“Veva! What's your bag?”

I looked up surprised, and looked back to my plate.

“Nothing.”

“Don't start being ungrateful about dinner when you were supposed to help.”

The boys and dad wisely stayed quiet.

She continued; “I had to found the right Sescentipedes for dinner which weren't marked by daddy myself, and also pumping water, all while cleaning the house.”

I didn't look at her and I started to feel really sick.

“I had to cook all the Sescentipedes separately because they wouldn't fit in one pot and it-”

“Shut up!” I interrupted my mother. I stood up, the chair creaking on the wooden floor.

“I am going to my bedroom,” and immediately turned around and walked up the stairs.

“Yeah you better go to your room, remember a stitch in time saves nine!”

I was not fast enough with throwing my door shut in time to not hear mother's stupid remark.

#

It already turned dark out, and I haven't left my room since I stormed away. I was getting bored and I was tired, yet I could not sleep. The noises were still roaming in my head. SNIP, SCREAM, TING. The indifference made me feel so icky, ashamed I would even dare saying. I know it was our job to cut their teeth and daddy told me it didn't hurt them. But I'd swear that their pain screeches were sincere. Then I thought about the Scentipedes we had for dinner tonight, how did they experience the pain when being boiled alive. “Could they feel it?” “Did they know what was happening?”. These thoughts and question kept me awake. That, and I was also hungry because I didn't touch my supper. That was when I remembered that Trisberry was still in the refrigerator. I could grab something to eat and check on her. When I stepped out my bed, I could hear the creaking floorboards. I immediately lifted my feet from the floor, trying to not make too much noise and wake everybody. Then something dawned on me. “Since when could I hear the floorboards cracking?” I thought. Normally, the noise would be drowned out by the bleats of the Auridents, even in the night. But tonight they were dead quiet. I stepped back on the floor, hearing the creaking noise as loud as I have ever heard it. I looked through the window of which I looked through so many times, where I was greeted by the thousands of Auridents in the field every morning. But tonight, they didn't

move an inch, none of them did. The lights that surrounded the enclosure, fixed on wooden poles didn't reveal any movement. It seemed like none of the uncountable Auridents decided to breath, let alone a lonely bleat. "Did I do this?" "Or daddy and I when we cut some of their teeth?" Worried, I ran to my mother's and daddy's bedroom across the hallway, not caring if I would make noise. As I stormed out the last time, I stormed in to their bedroom.

"Daddy, daddy, there is something wrong with the Auridents?" I said when I turned on the light.

"What... What are you saying," struggling opening his eyes

"Shut up and go to bed," mother said while pushing her pillow against her head.

"The Auridents, they aren't moving!"

"The Armorbents? Who are the? Oh the 'Auridents' what is with them sweetie?"

"You have to come check on them."

Before daddy was completely awake, he already stood in his knitted one-piece pajama with a lantern in his hand. I stood close behind him. We stepped from the patio on the red dirt, my white socks and daddy's grey nightwear ruined. Still complete silence from the multitude of Auridents. I got afraid for a second because I heard strange watery noises. But it turned out to just be the algeon-chickens swimming around, something you couldn't normally hear because of the dominant Auridents. When we stepped closer to the enclosure, we hoped that the animals would be afraid of us, step back a few paces, showing some motion, but they didn't.

But when daddy shined the light on the Auridents, we stepped back a few paces. Every Aurident was gone, and was replaced with a greyish cocoon. As far as the light could guide us, grey cocoons were nested on the red ground. Looking up to daddy, I could see the ball in his throat shoot up, and fall back down.

"You stay here," he said, unsure of himself.

He opened the fence door that was between us and the mysterious grey blobs. Stepping in the missing Auridents feces and red dirt, daddy walked up to the nearest cocoon. I felt the breeze touch the back of my neck and my ankles. I walked after daddy and when I grabbed the side of his pants, daddy was too distracted to notice. Holding the lantern close to the cocoon, it was revealed it was somewhat translucent. Hissing noises came from inside the grey matter. Then, a shape inside the cocoon seemed to move, as if it almost could see it was being observed. The thing scurried inside the cocoon for a few seconds. Daddy and I were frozen in fear. But then it stopped midmovement. The thing inside was pushing against the thin flesh of the cocoon, pressing his imprint through it. It was the head of an Aurident, but much more monstrous, bigger eyes, bigger head, bigger teeth...

HISSING, HISSING from every cocoon in the field followed with. The cocoons started trembling. Dad and I stepped back, without looking away. The cocoon in front of us exploded. Blue goo shot every which way. And out came a monstrous creature, vaguely resembling an Aurident. The beast looked as if it had the lust to kill and showed it big golden teeth. Daddy pushed me back to the house.

“Go Veva! Go fast!”

I ran back, with daddy behind me. He was much faster and picked me up by my side. Carrying me towards the farmhouse, his steps on the muddy sands got drowned out by hissing and the popping of cocoons. The beast scream sounded over the farm, the same I heard back in the workshop. But this time, scarier and furious. We ran up the patio into the house. With a deafening force, daddy slammed the door shut. At the top of the stairs stood Barry and Timmy in their matching pajama, rubbing their eyes and Berry holding his stuffed cute animal toy.

“What's that noise?” the tired Timmy said.

“Come down here and help me move the bookcase!” daddy demanded.

Slowly the two walked down the stairs.

“Now!”

Mother came in walking in her purple nightgown, her hair in a mess.

“What in tarnation is all this yelling?”

“Karen, help Veva with barricading the dining room window. NOW!”.

Daddy and the boys were pushing the bookcase in front of the door, while Mother and I flipped the dinner table on its side, blocking the window. As we pushed it against the window, Mother saw the beasts climbing over the fences and crawl to the farmhouse.

“What are they? It's hundreds!”

“Are the doors locked?” daddy said stern.

“I don't know.” she said worried.

“Then lock'em.”

Mother turned around and ran to the kitchen to lock the back door.

At this time, my eyes had finally managed to develop tears. As I said on the staircase, scared and shook.

“What's out there? What's out there?” the boys asked in canon.

That opened his mouth, but quickly overtook himself.

“Go upstairs, make sure all the windows are locked and come back. And don't look through them!”

Daddy was trying to protect his children from the truth, which was the horror nearing outside. This is something he had always done, but I have seen it. After placing the coathanger between the already locked door's handles, he crouched beside me.

“Don't worry sweetheart, you're safe behind these walls.”

BANG.

A beast ran into the door, making the entire wall shiver. Muffled hissing traveled through the walls. Floorboards on the patio were creaking as the Auridents were surrounding

our home. Daddy looked back at the door, he stared at it as if he could keep the doors shut by simply using his mind.

“Daddy... are they gonna eat us?” I said under the blades of my hair.

He looked back. It was the first time I saw fear in his face. Mother ran into the hallway.

“They have surrounded the house.” she tried to whisper but failed.

The front door got beaten and slashed by the sharp claws of the beings outside. Wood started to splinter on the edges and dust fell from the ceiling.

Mother crouched down beside daddy and hugged him. That felt like the only thing we could do, and I hugged him as well. Briefly, we hugged, feeling safe for a second or two. Until the window in the dinner room broke. Glass tumbled on the floor like those golden teeth. The hissing was uninterrupted and loud. The safety we felt in each other's arms was gone.

Dad stood up, “Timmy, Barry, come down here as quickly as you can!”

He looked down at Mother and I; “we need to go to the basement.”

Timmy and Barry ran down the stairs and joined us in the hallway. We followed Mother into the basement, while daddy picked up his trixium-lock rifle from the shelf in the living room.

The windows were bursting on all sides of the house. The front door, almost loose from its hinges.

In a line, we went down into the blackness on the creaking wooden steps of the basement. Mother pulled the cord of the single light bulb, illuminating the cement box our basement was. Daddy was the last person and locked the door behind us. We huddled in a corner, shivering against each other.

There we were. Locked in dark windowless room, waiting for whatever it was they wanted from us. Powerless and afraid.

No one said anything. There was nothing to say. Daddy and Mother could say everything would be fine, but we all knew that was a lie. The only thing we heard were claws scratching on the floors inside the house. Heavy paws walking above us, breaking Mother's decoration plates, tearing down our curtains and furniture. We could hear hissing noises and sniffing through the gap under the door. But all of that got dwarfed by the iron clashing noises that came from the refrigerator. Big dents forming on the side of the industrial machine.

Trissy.

As the metal doors were forced open with mighty brawn from inside, daddy cocked his gun. Pointing it at the refrigerator door, I knew it was futile. The only thing I could think of was: "Would Trissy ever forgive me?"